



Hawick Express: The idea for this came when on a research trip to a number of Border newspaper offices looking for writing in local dialect. A huge rugby player heaved himself up the narrow stairs of one of them (the *Eskdale and Liddesdale Advertiser*) to announce to the editorial staff changes in the team's line-up for that weekend in the broadest Border tongue and realising, to my delight, that I had only the vaguest idea of what he was actually saying. The Border towns are marked by their fierce local patriotism, celebrated in this verse from *The Border Queen* by James Thomson:

Where Slitrig dances doon the glen
 To join the Teviot waters,
 There dwell auld Hawick's honest men,
 And Hawick's bright-eyed daughters,
 And weel we lo'e the guid auld toon,
 Ilk nuik frae end to end on't,
 She aye has kept the causa croon,
 And ever independent.

Chorus—

What tho' her lads are wild a wee,
 And ill to keep in order,
 'Mang ither toons she bears the gree,
 The Queen o' a' the Border.